

The Ramayana – Complete Story

The Kingdom of Ayodhya

Once upon a time, in the ancient kingdom of Ayodhya, there ruled a wise and righteous king named **Dasharatha**. He was a great warrior, loved by all his subjects, and his kingdom prospered under his rule. Dasharatha had three queens — **Kausalya**, **Kaikeyi**, and **Sumitra**. He performed many yajnas (sacred rituals) to please the gods and ask for sons. Finally, his prayers were answered, and he had four sons:

1. **Rama** — born to Queen Kausalya, the eldest and most virtuous
2. **Bharata** — born to Queen Kaikeyi, deeply devoted to Rama
3. **Lakshmana** — born to Queen Sumitra, Rama's inseparable companion
4. **Shatrughna** — born to Queen Sumitra, devoted to Bharata

Among them, **Rama** was the most perfect — brave, kind, intelligent, and a master of all royal arts. He was the crown prince and everyone in Ayodhya loved him.

The Marriage of Rama and Sita

When Rama and Lakshmana came of age, Sage **Vishwamitra** took them to protect his yajna from demons. On this journey, they traveled to the kingdom of Mithila, ruled by King **Janaka**. King Janaka had a daughter named **Sita**, who was not born of a human womb — she had been found in a furrow of the earth while Janaka was ploughing a field. She was considered a divine blessing, a child of Mother Earth herself.

King Janaka had a divine bow, which was incredibly heavy. No one in the world could lift it. He declared that whoever could lift and string the bow would win Sita's hand in marriage. **Rama**, with ease, lifted the bow and strung it — but as he drew it to its full length, the bow snapped into two pieces with a thunderous sound!

Rama married Sita, and Lakshmana married Sita's sister, **Urmila**. Bharata married **Mandavi**, and Shatrughna married **Shrutakirti** — all cousins of Sita. The four brothers and their brides returned to Ayodhya, and the city celebrated their wedding for days.

The Exile of Rama

Years later, King Dasharatha decided it was time to crown Rama as the next king. The entire city rejoiced. But Queen **Kaikeyi**, influenced by her wicked maid **Manthara**, became jealous and afraid. She demanded two boons that Dasharatha had promised her long ago when she had saved his life in battle:

First boon: Her son Bharata should be crowned king instead of Rama.

Second boon: Rama must be exiled to the forest for **fourteen years**.

Dasharatha was heartbroken. He begged Kaikeyi to reconsider, but she was stubborn. Bound by his promise, the king had to agree.

Rama, ever the obedient son, accepted the exile without complaint. He said, "I will gladly leave for the forest. My father must never break his word."

Sita insisted on accompanying him, and **Lakshmana** refused to leave his brother's side. The three of them set off into the forest, wearing simple robes. The people of Ayodhya wept as their beloved prince departed.

Life in the Forest and the Abduction of Sita

In the forest, they lived a simple life. They met and befriended many sages and demons. They built a hut and lived peacefully for many years.

One day, the demoness **Shurpanakha**, the sister of the demon king **Ravana**, saw Rama and fell in love with him. When Rama refused her advances, she tried to attack Sita. Lakshmana intervened and cut off her nose and ears. Enraged, Shurpanakha went to her brother Ravana and told him about Sita's beauty.

Ravana, the powerful king of Lanka, decided to abduct Sita. He took the form of a golden deer and wandered near Rama's hut. Sita, enchanted by the deer, asked Rama to catch it for her. Rama chased the deer into the forest. When he shot it with an arrow, the deer screamed in Rama's voice to trick Lakshmana. Sita panicked and forced Lakshmana to go help Rama, leaving her alone.

Ravana then appeared as a wandering sage and tricked Sita. He picked her up and flew away on his flying chariot to Lanka.

Jatayu, the noble eagle king, tried to rescue Sita but was fatally wounded by Ravana. In his last moments, he told Rama about the direction Ravana had taken and died.

Rama was devastated. He and Lakshmana searched everywhere for Sita.

The Monkey Alliance

During their search, they met the monkey king **Sugriva**, who had been exiled from his kingdom by his brother **Vali**. Rama helped Sugriva defeat Vali, and in return, Sugriva promised to help Rama find Sita. He sent his most trusted minister, **Hanuman**, to search for her.

Hanuman, the son of the wind god, was immensely powerful. He could change his size, fly, and leap across the ocean. He reached Lanka, found Sita in Ravana's garden, and assured her that Rama would come to rescue her. He also brought back proof to Rama — Sita's ring.

The Battle of Lanka

Rama, Lakshmana, and the monkey army marched to the southern coast. With Hanuman's help, the monkeys built a floating bridge (Ram Setu) across the ocean to Lanka.

A great war began. Many brave warriors fought — including Ravana's son **Meghnad** (Indrajit), who had magical powers, and his giant brother **Kumbhakarna**, who was awakened only for battle. Kumbhakarna was defeated by Rama, and Indrajit was killed by Lakshmana.

Finally, Rama faced Ravana in a fierce duel. Rama used a divine weapon given by Sage Agastya and struck Ravana's heart, defeating him and ending his evil reign.

The Return to Ayodhya

Rama rescued Sita, but she had to prove her purity by walking through fire (Agni Pariksha). She emerged unharmed, and Rama accepted her back.

The exile was over. Rama, Sita, and Lakshmana returned to Ayodhya. The people lit lamps of oil to welcome them home — a celebration known today as **Diwali**.

Rama was crowned king and ruled with justice, kindness, and righteousness. His reign, **Rama Rajya**, is remembered as a golden era of peace and prosperity. Everyone lived happily and without fear. 🚀